***Board 1***
West Deals
None Vul

♠ K Q J 9 6 5
♥ A K
♦ 8 7 5
♣ A 5

♠ 7
♥ J 7 6
♦ K 9 6 3 2
♣ 7 6 4 3

♠ 2
♥ 9 5 3 2
♦ A Q J 10 4
♣ Q 9 8

♠ A 10 8 4 3
♥ Q 10 8 4
♦ —
♣ K J 10 2

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pass | 1♠ | Pass | 4♦ |
| Pass | 4NT | Pass | 6♦ |
| Pass | 7♠ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

7♠ by North
Lead: ♥3

Partner's 4♦ bid is a Splinter Bid. It shows opening hand strength, at least 4-card ♠ support, and a singleton or void in ♦s.

Normally you would not ask for Key-Cards with this ♦ holding. But since you know partner has at most a singleton, and that it is not the singleton ♦A, you are safe to do so. You say 4NT, partner replies 6♦. What next?

WOW! Partner has one Key-Card and a ♦ void. So the Key-Card is the ♠A. You don't know what the rest of partner's hand is, but he can surely take care of that small ♣. You bid 7♠.

***Board 2***
West Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ J 9 6 2<br>♥ J 9 5 3<br>♦ 5 2<br>♣ 4 3 2 | |
| ♠ A Q 5<br>♥ 4<br>♦ A K 10 8 6 3<br>♣ A K Q | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ K 8 7<br>♥ A 10 6<br>♦ Q 9 7 4<br>♣ J 10 8 |
| | ♠ 10 4 3<br>♥ K Q 8 7 2<br>♦ J<br>♣ 9 7 6 5 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2♣ | Pass | 2NT | Pass |
| 3♦ | Pass | 4♦ | Pass |
| 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♣[2] | Pass |
| 5♥ | Pass | 5♠ | Pass |
| 7NT | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards

7NT by East
Lead: ♥K

Your 2NT response shows 8+ points, with no 5-card biddable suit.

You support the ♦s and partner bids 4NT. What is your next bid?

With ♦s as trump you have 1 Key-Card, the ♥A. You answer 5♣ and partner bids 5♥. What is your bid?

This is the Queen Ask, wanting to know if you hold the ♦Q. Since you do have it you should bid a suit in which you hold a King. So you bid 5♠. That spurred partner on - he was fishing for 7♦ but when you told him you had the ♦Q, ♥A and ♠K he was able to bid 7NT.

***Board 3***
West Deals
E-W Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ Q 8<br>♥ A J 9 7<br>♦ K Q J<br>♣ A K Q 6 | |
| ♠ 10 9 7 4 3<br>♥ 4<br>♦ 10 9 6 2<br>♣ 9 4 3 | | ♠ A K J 6 5 2<br>♥ 5<br>♦ A 8 7 4<br>♣ 7 5 |
| | ♠ —<br>♥ K Q 10 8 6 3 2<br>♦ 5 3<br>♣ J 10 8 2 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pass | 2♣ | Pass | 2♥ |
| Pass | 3♥ | Pass | 3♠ |
| Pass | 4NT | Pass | 6♥ |
| All Pass | | | |

6♥ by South
Lead: ♦10

Partner's 2♥ is a positive response, 8+ points with a 5+ card suit.

Even though it is tempting, bidding RKCB now would be a mistake because of your doubleton ♠ loser. Instead just support the ♥s. Partner cannot pass, you both know you are forced to game. In fact, partner bids 3♠.

Partner promises first round ♠ control so NOW you can bid RCKB. When you bid 4NT partner answers 6♥. This shows 1 Key-Card and a void in a suit higher than ♥s. Knowing you are missing either the ♦A or ♥K you pass.

***Board 4***
West Deals
Both Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 6<br>♥ Q 4 3<br>♦ Q J 7 5 2<br>♣ Q J 8 3 | |
| ♠ A Q J 8 5 4 3<br>♥ 7<br>♦ A K 4<br>♣ A K | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ K 10 7 2<br>♥ A K 8 6 5<br>♦ 8 3<br>♣ 6 4 |
| | ♠ 9<br>♥ J 10 9 2<br>♦ 10 9 6<br>♣ 10 9 7 5 2 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2♣ | Pass | 2♥ | Pass |
| 2♠ | Pass | 3♠ | Pass |
| 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♥[2] | Pass |
| 5NT[3] | Pass | 6♦ | Pass |
| 7NT | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards without the trump queen
3. asks for kings

7NT by West
Lead: ♦5

Your 2♥ response shows 8+ points, with at least 5 ♥s.

Your hand is looking better and better. You already gave a positive response so you know you are forced to game. It is better to keep the bidding low to allow more investigating room so you bid 3♠. Partner bids 4NT. What is your response?

With ♠s agreed as trumps you have two Key-Cards, the ♠K and the ♥A. With no trump Queen you respond 5♥. Partner now says 5NT. What do you reply?

Partner is asking for Kings and you have just 1, the ♥K. Remember, the ♠K is not a King, it is a Key-Card which you have already counted. So you bid 6♦. Partner counts 13 tricks and bids 7NT.

***Board 5***
West Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A K 9 6 5 4<br>♥ K Q 6<br>♦ K Q J 2<br>♣ — | |
| ♠ 8 2<br>♥ J 9 4 2<br>♦ A 7<br>♣ 9 8 4 3 2 | | ♠ 10<br>♥ 10 7 5 3<br>♦ 9 5 3<br>♣ A Q 10 7 6 |
| | ♠ Q J 7 3<br>♥ A 8<br>♦ 10 8 6 4<br>♣ K J 5 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pass | 1♠ | Pass | 3♠ |
| Pass | 4♣ | Pass | 4♥ |
| Pass | 6♠ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

6♠ by North
Lead: ♦3

Partner's 3♠ is a limit raise, 11-12 points and good ♠ support.

What you DO NOT say next is 4NT. If partner answered 1 Key-Card you would not know what to do. If he has a red Ace you can make slam, but if his one Key-Card were the ♣A you couldn't. Instead you make a control-showing bid of 4♣, promising first round control. Partner obliges you by bidding 4♥. What is your next bid?

Partner's bidding is like the Sherlock Holmes tale Silver Blaze, about the dog that didn't bark. Partner's ♥ bid shows that he **DOES** have the ♥A, but equally important it shows that he **DOES NOT** have the ♦A. So you know you don't have a ♥ loser but do have a ♦ loser. You bid 6♠.